

Session 10: Joseph and Potiphar's Wife

Key Takeaways

- Yoseph acts as both the forbidden tree and the human who must listen to God's voice and pass the test. Biblical authors use keywords to evoke earlier stories while being dynamic in how they form the analogies.
- Potiphar's wife, who seeks illicit sex for personal pleasure, is set in meaningful juxtaposition with Tamar, who engages in illicit sex to seek justice and preserve life in the previous chapter.
- Yoseph rightly discerns that sin against another human, an image of God, is sin against God himself.
- Repetition of "laugh," Isaac's name as a verb, in the account of Potiphar's wife's deception continues the pattern of linking Yoseph to the binding of Isaac.

Yoseph's Rise and Fall and Rise

Genesis 39:1-23

39:1-6

A – Yoseph Enslaved, but Elevated Over Potiphar's House

- 39:2 "Yahweh was with Yoseph, and he was successful"
- 39:4 "And he appointed him over his house and gave everything of his into his hand"

39:7-19

B – Potiphar's Wife Traps Yoseph and Deceives Her Husband

- 39:9 "There is no one greater in this house than me ... how could I sin against God?!"
- 39:12 "And he left his garment in her hand, and he fled outside"

39:20-23

A' – Yoseph Imprisoned, but Elevated Over the Prisoners

- 39:21 "Yahweh was with Yoseph"
- 39:22 "The captain of the prison gave all the prisoners into the hand of Yoseph"

Genesis 40:1-23

40:1-8

Pharaoh's Baker and Cup-Bearer Are Imprisoned Along With Yoseph

- **The two men each have a dream** and ask Yoseph to interpret
- **40:8** "Do not interpretations belong to Elohim?"

40:9-19

The Two Men Recount Their Dreams and Yoseph Interprets Their Meaning

40:20-23

The Interpretations Come to Pass, but the Cup-Bearer Doesn't Remember Yoseph

Genesis 41:1-54

41:1-16

A – Pharaoh Has **Two Dreams About 2x7 Cows and Sheaves of Grain and Yoseph Interprets**

- **41:9** "Today I will make my sin remembered ..."
- **41:14** "Pharaoh summoned Yoseph ... and **he changed his garments** and came to Pharaoh"
- **41:16** Yoseph to Pharaoh: **"Not me! Elohim will give Pharaoh a response"**

41:17-36

B – Yoseph Interprets Pharaoh's Two Dreams Regarding 2x7 Years of Abundance and Famine

- **41:29-30** "7 years of abundance are coming ... followed by 7 years of famine afterward"

41:37-54

A' – Pharaoh Elevates Yoseph to Become Ruler Over All of Egypt

- **41:38** "Can another man be found like this, **in whom is the Spirit of Elohim?"**
- **41:40** **"You will be over my house ... only in the throne will I be greater than you"**
- **41:41** **"Look, I set you over all of Egypt,' and Pharaoh put his ring onto the hand of Yoseph"**

Genesis 39:1-41:57. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

These three chapters bring the story to its first plot climax, as Yoseph's dreams and enslavement come to a culminating point. The section has three large parts designed with symmetrical order, and each of those parts has a three-part symmetry.

- Part 1 (Gen. 39:1-23) is about Yoseph's elevation in Potiphar's house, how Yahweh was with him, and how Potiphar placed him as a second-self in command of the household. It's also about a further downfall due to the deception of Potiphar's wife, and another loss of a garment that marks his further descent into prison.

- Part 2 (Gen. 40:1-23) picks up the double-dream theme of Genesis 37, and Yoseph interprets the two dreams of Pharaoh's officials, which opens the door for him to interpret Pharaoh's dreams in the next part.
- Part 3 (Gen. 41:1-54) is about Yoseph's elevation in the house of Pharaoh because of Elohim's presence with him that enables him to interpret dreams. Yoseph is elevated to second-in-command under Pharaoh and given new garments that mark his ascent to royal rule.

Innocent Yoseph Is Deceived by Potiphar's Wife

Genesis 39:1-6

Joseph Elevated in Potiphar's House

- 39:2 "Yahweh was with Joseph and he was successful"
- 39:3 "everything Joseph was doing (כל אשר הוא עשה), Yahweh made successful"
- 39:4 Potiphar "appointed Joseph over his house, and gave everything into his hand"
- 39:5 "Yahweh blessed the house of the Egyptian on account of Joseph"

Genesis 39:7-19

39:7-10

Joseph Refuses Potiphar's Wife 2x + Joseph's Honest Speech

- 39:7 And she said, "Lay down with me!"
- 39:8, 10 "And he refused ... and he didn't listen to her"

39:11-12

Joseph's Refusal and Flight

- "She seized him by his garment, saying 'Lay down with me!!' "
- 39:12 And he abandoned his garment in her hand.

39:13-19

Potiphar's Wife Reports the "Incident" 2x + the Wife's Deceptive Speech

- 39:14 "He came in to lay down with me"
- 39:17 "He came to me, to play with me"

Genesis 39:20-23

Joseph Elevated in the Prison House

- 39:21 Yahweh extended loyal-love to Joseph, and gave him favor in the eyes of the captain.
- 39:22 The captain gave all the prisoners into the hand of Joseph.

- 39:22 “Everything they were doing (כל אשר עשה), he was doing (הוא היה עשה)”
- 39:23 “Yahweh was with Joseph ... Yahweh made him successful”

Genesis 39:1-23. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

This chapter is designed as a massive three-part symmetry with matching outer parts (Gen. 39:1-6 and 39:20-23) and a large center that itself has three symmetrically arranged parts (Gen. 39:7-19).

- Part 1 (Gen. 39:1-6) narrates Yoseph’s success and elevation in the house of Potiphar because of Yahweh’s presence with him. As a result, Yoseph is exalted to a place of second-in-command over his master’s house.
- Part 2 (Gen. 39:7-19) recounts Yoseph’s downfall in Potiphar’s house, due to his deceptive wife. There are three scenes here, beginning with his first refusal of the wife’s advances (Gen. 39:7-10), and this is matched by her speech that twists the story to her own advantage (Gen. 39:13-19). In the center (Gen. 39:11-12) is Yoseph’s defining moment, where he overcomes his test and has to flee naked.
- Part 3 (Gen. 39:20-23) narrates Yoseph’s success and elevation in the prison. The prison captain sees Yoseph’s abilities due to Yahweh’s presence, and he places Yoseph over the prison just as Potiphar did.

A

- a ¹ Now Yoseph had been **taken down** to Egypt;
 b and **Potiphar** bought him:
 c an officer of Pharaoh,
 c' the captain of the butchers,
 c'' an **Egyptian** man (איש מצרי)
 b' from **the hand** of the Yishmaelites,
 a' who had **taken him down** there.

B

- ² And **Yahweh was with Yoseph**,
 and he became a **successful man** (איש מצליח).
 And he was in **the house** of **his master** the **Egyptian**.

A'

- a ³ And **his master** **saw** (ראה) that **Yahweh was with him**
 b and that **everything that he was doing** (כל אשר הוא עשה) **Yahweh made successful** (מצליח) in **his hand**.
 a' ⁴ And Yoseph found **favor in his eyes** (חן בעיניו)
 b' and he attended him,
 a and **he appointed him over his house**,
 b and **everything that was his** (כל יש לו),
 a' **he** gave into **his hand**.
 a ⁵ And it came about **from the time he appointed him in his house**
 b and over **everything that was his** (כל אשר יש לו),
 a' Yahweh **blessed the house** of the **Egyptian** on account of Yoseph;

- 1 and Yahweh's (וַיְהִי) **blessing** was on **everything that was his** (כָּל אֲשֶׁר יֵשׁ לוֹ),
in **the house** and in the field.
- 2 6 And **he abandoned** (עָזַב) **everything that was his** (כָּל אֲשֶׁר לוֹ)
into **the hand** of Yoseph;
- 3 and he did not know anything with him,
except the bread which he ate.
- +1 And Yoseph (וַיְהִי) was beautiful of **form** (תֵּאֵר)
and beautiful of **sight** (מֵרָאָה) .

Genesis 39:1-6. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph's Two Refusals and Honest Speech

- 7 And it came about after these things
and the wife of his master **lifted her eyes toward Yoseph**
and she said, " **Lie with me** ."
- 8 **and he refused**.
-
- a And he said to **the wife of his master** ,
- b 9 "Behold, **my master** does not know, with me, what is **in the house**,
c and **everything that is his** (כָּל אֲשֶׁר יֵשׁ לוֹ) **he has given into** **my hand** .
- b' There is no one greater **in the house** than me,
c' and **he has not withheld anything from me** except you, because you are his wife.
d' And how could I do this great evil and sin against God?"
-
- 10 **And it came about as she spoke** **to Yoseph day after day**,
he did not listen to her
to lie next to her,
to be with her.

The "Incident"

- 11 And it came about on this day
that **he went into the house** (הַבֵּיתָה) to do his work,
and no man from the men of **the house** was there **in the house**.
- 12 And she seized him by **his garment**,
saying, " **Lie with me** !"
and **he abandoned** (עָזַב) **his garment** in **her hand**
and he fled,
and he went outside (הִחְצָה) .

The "Incident" Recounted in the Wife's Two Deceptive Speeches

13 And it came about when (וַיְהִי כֹ) she saw
 a that **he abandoned (עָזַב)** **his garment** in **her hand**
and he fled outside ,
 b 14 then **she called out** to the men of **her house**
 and **she said to them** , saying
 c “See, **he has brought in (לְ) (הֵבִיא לְ) a Hebrew man to us to play with us**;
 c’ he came to (בֹּא אֵלַי) me to **lie with me** ,
 b’ and **I called out with a great voice** ,
 15 and it came about when (וַיְהִי כֹ) he heard that **I raised my voice and called out** ,
 a’ then **he abandoned (עָזַב)** **his garment** **next to me** ,
and he fled and he went outside .”

16 And she rested **his garment** **next to her** ,
 until **his master** came to **his house** .

17 And **she spoke to him** **with** **these words** , saying
 “He came to me (בֹּא אֵלַי), the **Hebrew slave** ,
whom you made come to us (לְ) (הֵבִיא לְ) , to play with me;
 18 and when **I raised my voice and I called out** ,
 then **he abandoned (עָזַב)** **his garment** **next to me** , **and fled outside** .”
 19 And it came about when (וַיְהִי כֹ) **his master** heard **the words** of **his wife** ,
 which **she spoke to him** , saying,
 “According to these **these spoken-words** **your slave** did it to me,”
 then his anger burned hot.

Genesis 39:7-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

20 And Yoseph’s master took him
and he gave (וָיָתַן) him **into the round-house** ,
 the place the king’s **prisoners** were;
 and he was there in **the round-house** .

21 And **Yahweh was with Yoseph**
 and he extended loyal-love to him,
 and gave him favor in the eyes (חָנוּ בְעֵינָיו) of **the captain (שָׂר)** of **the round-house** .

22 And **the captain (שָׂר)** of **the round-house** **gave (וָיָתַן)**
 into **the hand** of Yoseph all the **prisoners** who were in **the round-house** ,
 and **everything they were doing there** ,
he was doing (כָּל אֲשֶׁר עָשִׂים ... הוּא הִיךָ עֹשֶׂה) .

23 And **the captain (שָׂר)** of **the round-house** did not see anything in **his hand**

in as much as **Yahweh was with him**,
and **whatever he was doing** (כל אשר הוא עשה), **Yahweh made it successful** (מצליח).

Genesis 39:20-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

More Deceptive Garments

Yoseph's garment is taken from him by Potiphar's lying wife and used to "prove" his guilt. // Yoseph's coat is taken from him by his lying brothers and used to "prove" his death. // Tamar's "deceptive garments" are used to trick Yehudah.

Genesis 27	Genesis 37	Genesis 38	Genesis 39
Yaaqov deceives his father Yitskhaq with the garment (בגד) of his older brother	Yaaqov's sons deceive their father with the robe (כתנת) of his youngest son	Tamar deceives Yehudah with garments (בגד) in order to produce a son	Potiphar's wife deceives her husband with the garments (בגד) of Yaakov's beloved son

Genesis 27 Reflected in Genesis 37-39. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph: The Exalted and Exiled Image of Elohim

This narrative is riddled with hyperlinks to [Genesis 1-3](#) that set Yoseph on analogy to the image of Elohim who is appointed to rule as second-in-command. But he is wrongly accused because of a deceiving woman and exiled even further down into an Egyptian pit of death.

Yoseph in Genesis 39	Humans in Genesis 1-3
Yoseph finds favor with Potiphar and is placed as second-in-command over all that belongs to him.	Elohim appoints man and woman as the divine image over all creation that ultimately belongs to Elohim.
Gen. 39:6a Potiphar doesn't "know" anything in his house except "the bread which he ate" (which in the narrative, turns out to be his wife, the forbidden food).	Adam and Eve do not yet have the "knowledge" of good and bad, but are to "eat" from any other trees in the garden.
Gen. 39:6b Yoseph was "beautiful of sight " (יפה מראה)	Gen. 3:5-6 "the woman saw (רא"ה) that the tree was ... desirable to the eyes ."

Comparing Joseph and Adam and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Yoseph in Genesis 39	Humans in Genesis 1-3
Gen. 39:9 “How (איך) could I do (עשה) this great evil (רעה) and sin against God (חטאתי לאלהים)?”	Gen. 3:13 “What is this thing that you have done (עשה)?”
Gen. 39:10 “As she spoke to Yoseph day after day, he would not listen (לא שמע) to her”	Gen. 3:17 “because you listened to the voice of your wife ...”
Gen. 39:13 “And when she saw ...”	Gen. 3:6 “and the woman saw that the tree was good ...”
Gen. 39:15 “And it came about when he heard (שמע) that I raised my voice (קול) he ran outside.”	Gen. 3:8 “And they heard (שמע) the sound (קול) of Yahweh walking ... and they hid themselves”
<i>Comparing Joseph and Adam and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

Yoseph is a contrast to Adam because he won't listen to the voice of the woman (Adam in Gen. 3:17) by sleeping with her. In this story, Yoseph becomes the forbidden fruit who is desirable to the eyes of Potiphar's wife (Potiphar's wife = “bread” in Gen. 39:6). He is wrongly seized by the woman, who then deceives her husband, resulting in Yoseph's expulsion, which leads him back into “the pit,” this time a “house of prison” (בית הסהר). Yoseph becomes an exiled Adam, not for any wrongdoing of his own, but because of the sin of Potiphar's wife. In this way, the Genesis 3 story is a contrast narrative with Yoseph as an anti-Adam.

Yoseph as a New Noah

Genesis 39:16 says, “And she rested (ותנח) his garment beside her” compared to Genesis 8:4 that says, “And the ark rested (ותנח) ... upon the mountains of Ararat.” This is a small hint that, like Noah, God has not forgotten Yoseph at his low point but will “remember” and deliver him.

Geneis 39:21 says, “And Yahweh ... gave him favor (חן) in the eyes of the captain of the house of confinement” compared to Genesis 6:8 that says, “Noah found favor in the eyes of Yahweh.”

The flood pattern hints continue, preparing us to view the famine as a “flood” of disorder out of which God will deliver a remnant, the family of Yaaqov, through Yoseph, who is the Noah figure.

Yoseph as a New Isaac

Genesis 39	Genesis 22
Gen. 39:7 “And the wife of his master lifted her eyes toward Yoseph”	Gen. 22:4 On the third day Abraham raised his eyes and saw the place from a distance.
Gen. 39:8-9 “My master doesn’t know (ידע) what is in the house ... There is not one greater in this house than I, and he has not withheld from me anything (לא חשך ממני מאומה) except you”	Gen. 22:12 “Don’t do to the boy anything (מאומה) , for I know (ידעת) that you fear God, and you have not withheld from me (לא חשכת ממני) your only son.”
Gen. 39:14 “Look, he has brought to us a Hebrew man to play/laugh at us (לצחק בנו)”	Gen. 21:9 Sarah sees the Egyptian Yishmael “playing/laughing” (צחק) , and exiles him to favor Yitskhaq/Laughter, who is to be sacrificed in Gen. 22.
Gen. 39:14 “And she cried out (ותקרא) ...”	Gen. 22:11 “And the angel of Yahweh cried out (ויקרא) ”
Gen. 39:10 “As she spoke to Yoseph day after day, he would not listen (לא שמע) to her.” Gen. 39:15 “And it came about when he heard that I raised my voice (כשמעו ... קולי) ”	Gen. 22:18 “because you listened to my voice (שמעת בקולי) ”
<i>Comparing Genesis 39 and Genesis 22. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

The point of these analogies: Yoseph, the beloved son of Yaaqov's old age, has been handed over to suffering and hardship because of evil human purposes providentially countered by God. Yoseph's exaltation over his brothers was a divine promise, but it became a cause of teenage arrogance. And so Yoseph's status was taken from him, as Isaac was taken from Abraham, only for both of them to receive back what they lost. Potiphar's wife becomes an inverted "Sarah" figure (Egyptian woman vs. Israelite). This clear Aqedah pattern at work in the Yoseph story maps closely onto the same patterns in chapter 37, where the goat is substituted for Yoseph to put blood on his coat.

Reflection Question

What earlier stories in Genesis do the biblical authors link to in Genesis 39?